SICILY 2026: THE NUMBERS BEHIND THE GROWTH OF INTERNATIONAL LUXURY TRAVEL

A market report for luxury travel advisors and hoteliers

PRESENTED AT
TRUE Sicily 2026

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

Sicily's tourism is now driven by international travellers, longer stays and rising hotel rates at the top of the market. This report brings together the latest published data: overall growth, the weight of foreign and North American demand, the performance of Palermo, Taormina and the southwest, and what it means for luxury travel advisors and hoteliers.

It was presented at TRUE Sicily 2026, the luxury travel trade event held at Verdura Resort from November 10 to 13, 2026.

Every figure in this report is sourced. Sources are listed at the end of each chapter and in full in the final section. The online edition, with linked sources and updates, is at https://truevent.eu/reports/sicily/2026.

KEY FIGURES

SICILY AT A GLANCE

+18.4%
overnight stays, January-August 2026 compared with 2024*

+4.9%
arrivals, January-August 2026 compared with 2024*

+5.8%
overnight stays, January-August 2026 compared with 2025

~13 million
international overnight stays in 2025 (+5.5%), more than half of the total

+8.5%
US and Canadian arrivals, first half of 2026

63.8%
international share of nights in Palermo in 2025 (54.7% in 2019)

~€1,500
average daily rate at Taormina's leading luxury hotels in 2025

+80%
real growth of that rate compared with 2018

1M+
visitors to the Valley of the Temples in the first half of 2026

*Two-year change obtained by compounding the January-August growth of 2025 and 2026. Sources: Regione Siciliana; Prometeia for UniCredit; Assoimpresa Italia; Comune di Palermo; HVS; Parchi archeologici della Regione Siciliana.

01

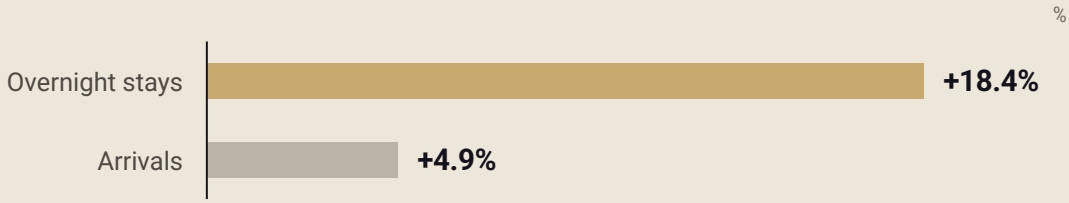
SICILY'S TOURISM GROWTH, 2024-2026

Sicily starts from a high base. According to regional figures, 2024 closed with about 7 million arrivals and more than 22.4 million overnight stays. In 2025 the total held steady at more than 22.5 million, but its composition changed: international nights rose 5.5% to almost 13 million, while Italian nights fell 6.3% to under 10 million.

The first eight months tell the same story of steady growth. From January to August 2025, overnight stays rose 11.9% and arrivals 1.3%. From January to August 2026, they rose a further 5.8% and 3.6%.

Compounding the two years, January-August 2026 is about +18.4% in overnight stays and +4.9% in arrivals compared with 2024. Nights have grown almost four times faster than arrivals: travellers are staying longer.

January-August 2026 compared with 2024 Compounded from the January-August growth of 2025 and 2026.



WHAT IT MEANS FOR LUXURY TRAVEL

More nights per trip mean more room nights and more spending on restaurants, private transfers, guides, experiences, wine, shopping and additional destinations on the island.

SOURCES Confimprese Palermo, 2024 regional data (Il Moderatore); Prometeia for UniCredit, 2025 (LaTr3); Osservatorio Turistico Regionale, January-August 2025 (GuidaViaggi); Regione Siciliana, January-August 2026 (PalermoToday).

02

INTERNATIONAL DEMAND IS DRIVING THE MARKET

~13M	+5.5%	-6.3%
international overnight stays in 2025	international nights, 2025 compared with 2024	Italian nights, 2025 compared with 2024

International travellers have become the main engine of Sicily's growth. In 2025 they generated almost 13 million nights, more than half of the total, while domestic demand softened.

The trend continued in 2026. In the first half of the year, arrivals from the United States and Canada rose 8.5% and from France 4.2%. A larger international base supports five-star hotels, luxury resorts, villas, DMC services, private transfers and a broader shoulder season.

SOURCES Prometeia for UniCredit, 2025 (LaTr3); Assoimpresa Italia, September 2026.

03

NORTH AMERICA: A LUXURY GROWTH MARKET

+8.5%	262,355	22%
US and Canadian arrivals, first half of 2026	American nights in Taormina in 2024	US share of international nights in Taormina

According to ISTAT, American and French travellers are the main foreign markets in Sicily. In Taormina, Americans spent 262,355 nights in 2024: 19% of all nights in the town and 22% of international nights.

North American growth directly supports the products where Sicily's luxury market is expanding:

- five-star hotels and resorts, suites and villas;
- private transfers and private guides;
- wine and gastronomy, yachts and celebration travel;
- multi-stop itineraries across the island.

SOURCES Assoimpresa Italia, September 2026; ISTAT, tourism flows 2024; Comune di Taormina data, 2024 (Gazzetta del Sud).

04

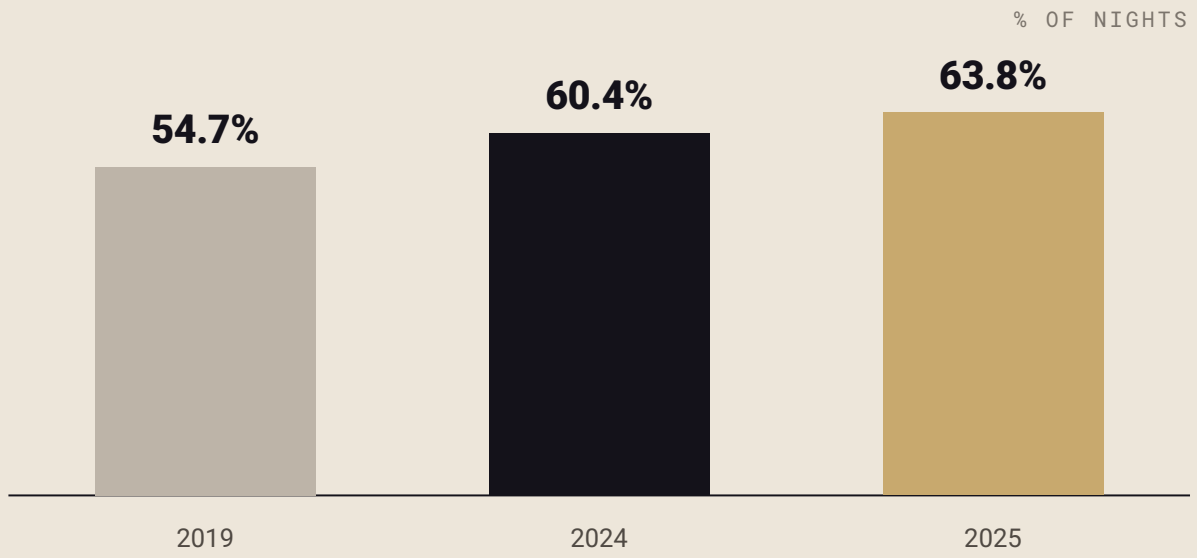
PALERMO: INTERNATIONAL DEMAND GAINS SHARE

2.1M
overnight stays in Palermo in 2025

+13.4%
international nights, 2025 compared with 2024

63.8%
international share of nights in 2025

Palermo: international share of nights



The largest increase by nationality in 2025, in absolute terms, came from the United States: +22,756 nights.

For luxury travel, Palermo is both a high-end city destination and the gateway to Western Sicily: Cefalù, Monreale, Scopello, Trapani, Marsala and the Egadi Islands.

SOURCES Comune di Palermo, 2025 tourism data (March 2026); Quattrocanti, Palermo 2025.

05

LUXURY HOTEL RATES ARE OUTGROWING THE MARKET

~€1,500	+80%	~76%
average daily rate at Taormina's leading luxury hotels in 2025	real growth of that rate compared with 2018	hotel occupancy in Taormina, April-October 2025

Taormina is the benchmark for luxury hospitality in Sicily. According to HVS, the town's average hotel rate exceeded €1,200 in 2025, and its leading luxury properties reached about €1,500, more than 80% above 2018 in real terms. Seasonal occupancy from April to October was about 76%, across roughly 1.4 million bed-nights.

Growth at the top of the market is driven mainly by rate rather than by volume. Sicily is growing in value per occupied room, not only in visitor numbers, and new luxury openings bring global sales networks, international PR and access to high-value distribution.

SOURCES HVS, Taormina Market Pulse 2026.

06

SOUTHWESTERN SICILY

1.73M	~46%	+15.9%
overnight stays in the Province of Agrigento in 2025	international share of nights	American nights, 2025 compared with 2024

American overnight stays in the province reached 103,227 in 2025, with an average stay of 3.8 nights. The area brings together Verdura, Sciacca, Agrigento, Selinunte and Menfi, in a market where international travellers already generate almost half of all nights.

The luxury opportunity is measurable: established resorts, major archaeology, wine and coastline can support longer stays and higher-value itineraries, while the area is still less internationally developed than Taormina or Palermo.

SOURCES Osservatorio Turistico Regionale, Agrigento 2025 (Travelnostop).

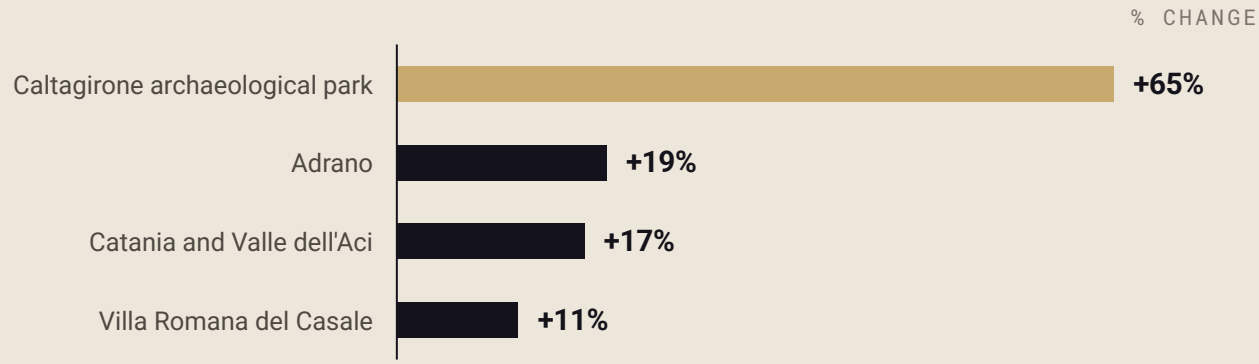
07

CULTURE IS GENERATING SCALE

1M+

visitors to the Valley of the Temples, first half of 2026

Visitors to archaeological parks, 2026 compared with 2025



Archaeology, architecture and historic cities give travellers reasons to visit outside the summer, and provide the content for private guiding, specialist access and multi-stop itineraries. For the luxury segment, cultural assets can turn a resort stay into a longer journey across Sicily.

SOURCES Parchi archeologici della Regione Siciliana, August 2026. Growth rates refer to the periods published by each park in August 2026.

08

A LONGER SEASON

+7%

visitors, January-March 2026 compared with 2025

65.6%

saturation of online accommodation, June-August 2026

+12%

experience bookings, 2026 estimate

The season is getting longer. Visitors rose about 7% from January to March 2026, while summer demand remained high: Sicily ranked among the top Italian regions for online accommodation saturation in June-August 2026. The opportunity is to grow April to June and September to November through culture, wine, gastronomy, archaeology and golf.

Longer stays and stronger demand for experiences, estimated at +12% in 2026, increase the value of private guides, restaurants, wineries, boats, drivers, artisans and cultural access. Growth in nights and experiences matters more economically than growth in arrivals alone.

SOURCES Regione Siciliana, January-March 2026 (PalermoToday); Italian Ministry of Tourism, summer 2026 (GuidaViaggi); Assoimpresa Italia, September 2026.

09

EAST AND WEST: TWO COMPLEMENTARY GROWTH STORIES

Eastern and Western Sicily are not competing destinations. Their different levels of international recognition, hotel infrastructure and visitor distribution can help sell richer, longer itineraries across the whole island.

Eastern Sicily: the established luxury benchmark

From Taormina and Mount Etna to Catania, Siracusa and the Val di Noto, Eastern Sicily combines international brand recognition, iconic cultural sites and a mature luxury hospitality offer.

~1.4M
bed-nights in Taormina in 2025

~76%
hotel occupancy in Taormina, April-October

22%
US share of international nights in Taormina (2024)

Taormina remains Sicily's most internationally established luxury destination. Heritage hotels, international hospitality brands, dramatic scenery and cultural programming have supported premium pricing, with leading luxury hotels averaging about €1,500 a night. These figures describe the top of the Taormina market, not an island-wide average.

Catania and Etna
Airport access, the volcanic landscape, wineries and outdoor experiences make a gateway for premium itineraries and shoulder-season demand.

Siracusa and Ortigia
Archaeology, architecture, waterfront hospitality and private cultural experiences appeal strongly to experiential luxury travellers.

Val di Noto
Noto, Modica and Ragusa bring UNESCO-listed Baroque heritage, design-led stays and a distinctive food identity.

Western Sicily: a growing luxury destination

Western and Southwestern Sicily bring together Agrigento, Sciacca, Menfi, Selinunte, Marsala, Trapani and Palermo. The area offers a complementary luxury proposition built on coastal resorts, archaeology, wineries and food, connected in an itinerary rather than centred on one resort town.

2.54M
overnight stays in the Province of Trapani in 2024

+26.74%
nights in the Province of Agrigento, 2025 compared with 2019*

514,897
overnight stays in Sciacca in 2025, first in its province*

The Agrigento-Sciacca corridor links the Valley of the Temples with resort hospitality and the surrounding coastline, and American nights in the province rose 15.9% in 2025.

Rocco Forte's Verdura Resort is an internationally recognised luxury anchor. Its golf, wellness, food and coastal setting support premium stays, and its location introduces guests to Agrigento, Selinunte and Menfi. The opportunity is to connect international resort demand with local guides, wineries, restaurants, transport and cultural experiences.

Selinunte and Menfi
Archaeology, vineyards and coastal experiences can extend resort-based stays.

Marsala and Trapani
Wine heritage, historic towns, the salt pans and access to the Egadi Islands support varied itineraries.

Palermo
A major international city gateway, cultural destination and complementary stop on a western itinerary.

A strategic role for TRUE Sicily 2026

The commercial goal is not simply to sell a second hotel, but more nights in Sicily. An itinerary linking Taormina, Etna and Siracusa with Agrigento, Sciacca and the western coast introduces new experiences, increases spending in the destination and gives returning clients a reason to explore further. Hosting TRUE at Verdura Resort showcases the southwest while keeping the whole island in view.

SOURCES HVS, Taormina Market Pulse 2026; Comune di Taormina data, 2024 (Gazzetta del Sud); Osservatorio Turistico Regionale, Trapani 2024 (Travelnostop); Camera di Commercio di Agrigento, 2025 (AgrigentoNotizie); Rocco Forte Hotels, Verdura Resort. *Camera di Commercio di Agrigento series, which excludes short-term rentals: not directly comparable with the regional series used elsewhere in this report.

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THE NUMBERS, AND WHAT THEY MEAN FOR THE TRADE

The numbers behind Sicily's growth

INDICATOR	PERIOD	CHANGE
Overnight stays	Jan-Aug 2026 vs 2024*	+18.4%
Arrivals	Jan-Aug 2026 vs 2024*	+4.9%
International nights	2025 vs 2024	+5.5%
US and Canadian arrivals	H1 2026 vs H1 2025	+8.5%
Palermo, international nights	2025 vs 2024	+13.4%
Agrigento, American nights	2025 vs 2024	+15.9%
Taormina, leading luxury hotel rates	2025 vs 2018, real terms	+80%
Experience bookings	2026, estimate	+12%

What it means for advisors and hoteliers

01 **Sell more nights, not only more arrivals.**
Nights are growing much faster than arrivals, and Sicily has the product for longer stays across several destinations.

02 **Build for international demand.**
Foreign travellers now generate more than half of all nights, and are increasingly important outside the summer peak.

03 **Treat North America as a core luxury market.**
Americans are among Sicily's main foreign markets, and US and Canadian arrivals grew 8.5% in the first half of 2026.

04 **Follow the rate growth.**
Taormina's leading hotels have grown their rates by more than 80% in real terms since 2018, a measure of the spending power at the top of the market.

05 **Watch Southwestern Sicily.**
Almost half of Agrigento's nights are international, and American nights are growing at double-digit rates.

06 **Sell the shoulder season.**
Culture, wine, food and golf give Sicily the product to grow beyond July and August.

FAQ

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

About Sicily

Is Sicily a luxury travel destination?

Yes. Taormina's leading luxury hotels average about €1,500 a night, more than 80% above 2018 in real terms. Palermo, Siracusa, the Val di Noto and the southwest around Verdura Resort complete an offer that combines luxury hotels and resorts with world-class archaeology, wine and food.

Is tourism in Sicily growing?

Yes. From January to August 2026, overnight stays rose 5.8% and arrivals 3.6% compared with 2025, about +18.4% in nights compared with 2024. International travellers now generate more than half of all nights.

How important are American travellers to Sicily?

Very. Americans are among Sicily's main foreign markets, and US and Canadian arrivals rose 8.5% in the first half of 2026. In Palermo, the United States recorded the largest increase in nights of any nationality in 2025.

When is the best time for luxury travel to Sicily?

April to June and September to November combine pleasant weather with culture, wine, food, archaeology and golf, and fewer crowds than July and August. Visitors rose about 7% from January to March 2026, a sign that the season is getting longer.

About TRUE

What is TRUE?

TRUE is Italy's leading luxury travel network and B2B event platform. It connects over 5,000 luxury travel advisors worldwide with more than 300 hotels, resorts, villas and DMCs in Italy through immersive regional events that combine one-to-one meetings with fam trips.

What is TRUE Sicily?

TRUE Sicily is the Sicilian edition of TRUE. It brings selected international travel advisors to meet Sicily's luxury hotels, resorts, villas and DMCs through B2B meetings, fam trips and immersive experiences. The 2026 edition took place at Verdura Resort from November 10 to 13, 2026.

What are the best luxury travel networking events in Italy?

TRUE runs regional luxury travel trade events in Puglia, Sicily, the Dolomites and Sardinia, with Campania and Tuscany from 2027. Each edition brings selected international travel advisors together with the region's luxury hotels, resorts, villas and DMCs.

How is TRUE different from a traditional travel trade show?

TRUE combines one-to-one B2B appointments with fam trips, site inspections and destination experiences. Each edition features only suppliers from the host region, and participation is all-inclusive.

Can travel advisors join a fam trip to Italy with TRUE?

Yes. Luxury travel advisors can apply to attend a TRUE edition. Selected advisors take part in an all-inclusive program of B2B meetings, fam trips and experiences in the host region.

How can travel advisors or hotels take part in TRUE?

Travel advisors can apply to attend a TRUE edition, and luxury hotels, resorts, villas and DMCs can join as exhibitors, through the TRUE application's forms.

TRUE

ABOUT TRUE: ITALY'S LEADING LUXURY TRAVEL NETWORK

TRUE is Italy's leading luxury travel network and B2B event platform, connecting over 5,000 luxury travel advisors worldwide with more than 300 hotels, resorts, villas and DMCs across Italy. Founded in 2022 by Luigi De Santis, TRUE has quickly become a reference point for luxury travel networking between Italian hospitality and the world's top travel advisors, especially from the United States, Latin America and Australia.

How TRUE works

Each TRUE event is dedicated to one Italian region and features only hotels, resorts, villas and DMCs from that region. Instead of a traditional trade show, TRUE uses an immersive format. Advisors meet exhibitors in pre-scheduled one-to-one B2B appointments, then experience the destination through fam trips, site inspections and curated experiences. Advisors come home knowing the product first-hand, and hotels meet buyers who are ready to sell. Participation is all-inclusive for both exhibitors and advisors, covering accommodation, B2B meetings, meals, transfers and events.

A growing network

Since 2022, TRUE has grown from a single event into a series of regional luxury travel events across Italy.

2026 editions
TRUE Puglia, TRUE Dolomites, TRUE Sardegna and TRUE Sicily.

2027
TRUE Campania and TRUE Tuscany join the calendar.

Selected advisors
Each year, hundreds of luxury travel advisors apply to attend TRUE, and about 180 top performers are selected, sent by the leading travel agencies and consortia in the US, Latin America and Australia.

Road to TRUE
Once a year, TRUE takes about 60 Italian luxury hotels abroad to meet around 150 buyers in a key market such as New York.

TRUEtalk
At every edition, a panel of hoteliers, buyers and journalists discusses the destination and the future of luxury travel.

Why hotels and advisors choose TRUE

For hotels, resorts, villas and DMCs

Direct access to qualified luxury travel advisors from high-value long-haul markets, in a setting where they experience your property instead of just hearing about it.

For travel advisors

An all-inclusive luxury fam trip in Italy combined with one-to-one meetings, destination training and relationships with the properties they sell.

NOTES

SOURCES AND NOTES ON METHOD

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- Osservatorio Turistico Regionale, Province of Trapani 2024 (Travelnostop, August 2025)
- Camera di Commercio di Agrigento, 2025 tourism data (AgrigentoNotizie)
- Rocco Forte Hotels, Verdura Resort

2026 data is partial

2026 figures cover part of the year and should not be read as full-year results.

Compounded two-year changes

The +18.4% in overnight stays and +4.9% in arrivals for January-August 2026 compared with 2024 are obtained by compounding the January-August growth of 2025 (+11.9% and +1.3%) and 2026 (+5.8% and +3.6%).

Different series

Regional figures include short-term rentals; ISTAT's accommodation-only series gives lower totals (about 17.3 million nights in Sicily in 2024), and the Camera di Commercio di Agrigento series also excludes short-term rentals. Figures from different series are not combined.

Summer saturation

The 65.6% for June-August 2026 is the saturation of accommodation offered online, as measured by the Ministry of Tourism, not total occupancy.

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>
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